

SETTING AND PURSUING GOALS IN RECOVERY # 65

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Accept the truth about the problems addiction has caused and enter a program of recovery.
2. Cooperate with addiction assessments and accept the diagnosis and treatment plan.
3. Formulate a set of personalized recovery goals.
4. Learn general goal-achievement life skills to enhance chances of long-term success and quality of life.
5. Increase investment in recovery and practice new skills between sessions and after treatment.

ADDITIONAL HOMEWORK THAT CAN BE APPLICABLE TO CLIENTS WHO EXPERIENCE TREATMENT RESISTANCE

- Consequences of Continuing Addictive Lifestyles
- Early Warning Signs of Relapse
- How Far Have I Come?
- Identifying Relapse Triggers and Cues
- Understanding My Defense Mechanisms
- Understanding Nonchemical Addictions
- What Do I Want for My Children?
- What Does Addiction Mean to Me?
- What's Addiction Got to Do with My Problems?

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

The “Setting and Pursuing Goals in Recovery” activity is intended for any client who is vague about what he/she wants to see change, or who appears to suffer from learned helplessness or excessive dependence on the counselor or others for direction and assistance. The exercise guides the client in setting concrete goals—identifying reasons, strategies, and resources for each—and making a therapeutic contract to carry out the strategies. Follow-up might include other exercises after some work on the goals set, such as those titled “What Do Others See Changing?” and “How Far Have I Come?”

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There may be much in our lives over which we have little or no control. This fact makes it more important that we change whatever harmful patterns we can. In choosing life without addictions, we have to change more than just quitting specific bad habits to support this lifestyle change.

1. Please list the changes you want to make in your life, beyond giving up addictive patterns, to support your recovery and avoid relapse. Be sure to list behaviors (things you do) and not characteristics (things you are). Behavior is changeable, while characteristics may not be. For example, people who are shy may not be able to stop being shy, but they can avoid the behavior of isolating themselves. Your goals (e.g., avoid isolating):

- a. _____
- b. _____
- c. _____
- d. _____

2. The reasons you want to make these changes:

- a. _____
- b. _____
- c. _____
- d. _____

3. Now list three methods you will use to achieve each of your goals. Describe what you'll do (e.g., attend three meetings per week, call a friend every day, join the local theater group).

Goal (a)

Method (1): _____

Method (2): _____

Method (3): _____

Goal (b)

Method (1): _____

Method (2): _____

Method (3): _____

Goal (c)

Method (1): _____

Method (2): _____

Method (3): _____

Goal (d)

Method (1): _____

Method (2): _____

Method (3): _____

4. The obstacles or barriers that could interfere with your achieving these goals, and the methods you will use to overcome these barriers:

Obstacles or Barriers

Methods You Will Use to Overcome

- | | | |
|----|-------|-------|
| a. | _____ | _____ |
| b. | _____ | _____ |
| c. | _____ | _____ |
| d. | _____ | _____ |

5. The ways other people can help you achieve these goals and the ways you will get that support from those people are:

Ways Others Can Help

Ways You Will Get Their Help

- | | | |
|----|-------|-------|
| a. | _____ | _____ |
| b. | _____ | _____ |
| c. | _____ | _____ |
| d. | _____ | _____ |

6. You will know that your plans are working if you see these things happening:

- | | |
|----|-------|
| a. | _____ |
| b. | _____ |
| c. | _____ |
| d. | _____ |

7. Your therapist and others will know that your plans are working if they see these things happening:

- | | |
|----|-------|
| a. | _____ |
| b. | _____ |
| c. | _____ |
| d. | _____ |

8. How often will you check your progress toward your goals and make any necessary changes in

your methods? _____

9. When do you plan to have finished achieving each of these goals?

- a. _____
- b. _____
- c. _____
- d. _____

10. Please fill out a Commitment Contract for each goal you set (the form is on the next page). You will sign this contract, as will your therapist and the people who will help you achieve each goal.

Be sure to bring this handout to your next therapy session, and be prepared to talk about your thoughts and feelings about the exercise.

Commitment Contract

1. I, _____, will work to accomplish the following goal: _____
and to do so by the following date: _____
2. I will take the following actions as my methods to achieve this goal:
Method (1): _____
Method (2): _____
Method (3): _____
3. My supporters who sign this contract agree to help me with the following supportive actions:

4. My therapist and I will meet to discuss my behavior-change progress and to confirm support for my behavior-change efforts on these dates:

5. If I don't make satisfactory progress toward this goal, I will take the following corrective action(s):

Your signature	Date	Signature of Counselor	Date
_____	_____	_____	_____
Signature of Supporter	Date	Signature of Supporter	Date
_____	_____	_____	_____
Signature of Supporter	Date	Signature of Supporter	Date